Cooper was making $4,500 a year, which to me seemed beyond the dreams ot avarice. Silverman, I speculated in my diary, "is probably getting even more." Then I wondered, "So why is Cooper so poor? He only has one suit, etc., etc."

The utter failure at the convention put me under a dank blanket

of apprehension concerning the future. I had for quite a while been totally absorbed in the gathering success of my research—the clear indication that I would have an interesting dissertation and therefore my degree. I couldn't help but view that as the climax of my education and my life, almost as though I were envisaging a cartoon in which I stood on a podium with light radiating from my head, stars going on and off, and the caption reading, "Success!"

Except that that's not how life is. It goes on, and by the time I had my degree, I must also have a job, and how was I going to get that? Aside from the lack of interest at the convention, the fact was that the job market had been declining steadily since the war, and as a Jew who spoke with a Brooklyn accent and, as anyone could tell at a single glance, lacked sophistication and poise, I was scarcely in the first rank of candidates for any job.

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There was the other side of my life—writing. After a summer's solid work, I finished "Grow Old with Me" on September 22, 1947, and it was forty-eight thousand words long. Only 'The Mule" had been longer, and not by much.

On the twenty-third, I took it in to Sam Merwin, who instantly greeted me with the news that Leo Margulies, his boss, had decided that the attempt to publish Astounding-type stories was a failure and he now wanted blood-and-thunder Amazing-type stories.

I shrugged that off. After all, he had specifically ordered this story, and on two separate occasions he had read portions, approved them, and urged me to continue. Whatever the requirements for the future, therefore, he was committed to this story, in my opinion. My chief fear was that he was going to use the change in policy as a device to get me to accept a lower word-rate. I told him quite firmly that $.02 a word was the price agreed upon.

Then, on September 25, I registered at Columbia University and began my thirteenth year as a student there. (Even during my years in the Navy Yard and the Army, I was kept on the Columbia books as a student in good standing.) Half my entire life, almost, had been spent at Columbia.